

THE DOLPHIN RETURNS

The discovery of an endangered species of dolphins in the Harike sanctuary has put the spotlight on the deteriorating wetland habitat

■ By Ramesh Vinayak

Wildlife in India is incredibly resilient. Nothing else can explain the discovery of dolphins recently in the unlikelyst of places—the Harike wetland in Punjab, which has so far been famous as a winter habitat for migratory waterfowl from lands as far away as Siberia. The first sighting in Harike of the Indus dolphin (*Platanista gangetica minor*), one of the seven surviving freshwater species of the aquatic mammal, and classified as a critically endangered species in the Red Data Book of the International Union for the Conservation of Nature and Natural Resources, has spread waves of amazement among wildlife enthusiasts. “In India’s drab wildlife scenario, this is the most significant find. It adds to the diversity of the country’s aquatic system,” says B.C. Choudhary, an authority on freshwater dolphins with the endangered species management wing of the Wildlife Institute of India, Dehradun.

The Eureka moment came on December 14, when Basanta Rajkumar, divisional forest officer in charge of the Harike wildlife sanctuary, was patrolling on a boat to follow up on reports of an unusually big fish in the huge water reservoir formed by the confluence of the Sutlej and the Beas. Initially, it was presumed to be the *mahseer*, a species of trout not common in the area. “When I noticed the smooth hump of the creature rapidly flipping out of the water, I knew it was a dolphin,” he says. A week later, a World Wildlife Fund (WWF)-India team, led by Sandeep Bahera, a freshwater dolphin conservationist, vindicated his surmise after sighting a family of half a dozen dolphins at two different places along the 25-km stretch upstream of the Beas.

With the United Nations declaring 2007 to be the Year of the Dolphin, the chance discovery couldn’t have come at a better time. So far, the only known sweet-water dolphin in India has been the Gangetic dolphin (*Platanista gangetica gangetica*), which inhabits the Ganga-Brahmaputra system. The Indus dolphin has been reported in the Indus river and its tributaries in Pakistan, which were once linked with the river system of Punjab. Last sighted in Punjab in the 1930s, the Indus dolphin was thereafter believed to have become extinct.

Though the origin of the Harike dolphins is still not clear, experts believe this to be a small sub-group of the Indus species that got sepa-



rated from the main population because of the construction of dams and barrages on the Indus river system in the 1950s, but survived extinction due to an ideal habitat. “These are resident breeding stock which survived in the Beas,” says Bahera—a possibility corroborated by the fact that the Indus dolphin is common in the same tributary about 140 km downstream of the Harike barrage, in Pakistan. With locals reporting native dolphins, known as *bhuland* (meaning big fish), for over a century, experts believe Indus dolphins have existed in Harike area for long but have somehow escaped scientific sighting. Authorities, however, are not ruling out the possibility that the dolphins travelled upstream into the Beas from the Indus tributaries in Pakistan during the 1988 floods, but this seems improbable considering the barrages on the way.

Of the Gangetic species, only 1,800 dolphins are reported to have survived. Despite a WWF conservation programme, their number has been dwindling due to degradation of habitat. Plagued by an alarming level of pollution, encroachments, indiscriminate fishing and government apathy, the ecological wonderland of Harike, too, faces a serious threat, as reflected in the dwindling number and species of migratory birds in recent years. This grim reality check has toned down the euphoria over the discovery. “This is a very small population of rare dolphins, which needs immediate conservation efforts,” says the WWF report.

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The area of illegal encroachments in Harike is pegged at 650 hectares, most of it dating back to the 1980s, when Harike was a popular hide-out for terrorists. Cultivation has led to the destruction of tall grass—a natural habitat for birds. The pesticide and fertiliser run-off from fields has added to the alarming level of pollutants. About 310 million litre of domestic and industrial efflu-